

The Law of Life

Jack London · 1901

First published: McClure's, Mar 1901

TEACHER EDITION · CURRICULUM UNIT

Common Core edition (standards shown for this framework only)

One 90-minute lesson (the whole story), with an optional take-home essay

Syllabus · 90-minute lesson plans · lecture scripts · vocabulary · quizzes with keys · writing prompts at eleven rigor levels · SAT-style items · whole-book test · essays

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Contents and unit overview

1. Unit overview and the 90-minute lesson
2. Syllabus (weekly pacing)
3. Lesson 1: introduction (author, context, reception, overview)
4. Lesson plans and lecture scripts (chapters 1–1), each with vocabulary, discussion questions, annotation focus, quiz and key, writing prompts and SAT-style items
5. Unit test (eleven rigor versions) with answer keys and scoring guides
6. Final paper
7. Essay assignments at eleven rigor levels

Edition: Reading text: https://en.wikisource.org/wiki/Children_of_the_Frost/The_Law_of_Life (revision 3806232), cleaned for Liber et Libri.

Grades: Grades 9–12 (accessible text, well suited to the scaffolded-support track; scales to graduate via rigor levels). Short story: read whole in one 90-minute lesson (assign longer stories as pre-reading). The scaffolded-support track works from the full text with scaffolds. **Weeks:** 1. **Class days:** 2 × 90 minutes (1 chapter lessons plus seminar, test and essay days).

Essential questions

- What does The Law of Life suggest about the cycle of life and death?
- What does The Law of Life suggest about age and community?
- What does The Law of Life suggest about acceptance?

Objectives

- Students will cite at least 2 quotations, with locations, to support each written claim about what the text says explicitly and implicitly (scored on the writing-prompt rubric).
- Students will trace one theme across at least 3 sections of the story in the final paper, earning at least 70 of 100 rubric points.
- Students will explain how characters, setting and point of view interact in at least 3 exit tickets, each meeting the claim-evidence-reasoning criteria.
- Students will determine the in-context meaning of taught vocabulary, scoring at least 80% on the vocabulary items of the story quizzes.
- Students will write an argument with a clear claim, reasons and relevant evidence, scoring at least 80% on the unit test's short-answer scoring guides.

Standards: Common Core

RL.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2, RL.9-10.3, RL.9-10.4, RL.9-10.5, RL.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2, RL.11-12.4, RL.11-12.5, W.9-10.1, W.11-12.1, L.9-10.4, L.11-12.4

Common Core State Standards (ELA-Literacy), thecorestandards.org

Assessments: Daily story quizzes (auto-graded); Weekly writing prompt (rubric); Socratic seminars (scheduled days); Whole-story test (scheduled day); Final essay (scheduled day); College Sophomore and above write one essay of the five
Differentiation: Every prompt and quiz has eleven rigor levels (Scaffolded support through Graduate / PhD); the app applies student override, then class standard, then the automatic level. Each prompt is tagged for Common Core, Indiana 2023, Dual Credit (Indiana College Core), AP and Cambridge where they apply.
Materials: Liber et Libri reader; Annotation journal; Story lecture slides or script

The 90-minute lesson

#	Segment	Mode	Minutes	Clock
1	Bell-ringer	You do	8	0–8
2	Vocabulary with etymology notes	I do	10	8–18
3	Background and context	I do	10	18–28
4	I do: modeled close reading	I do	12	28–40
5	We do: guided annotation	We do	15	40–55
6	You do: independent annotation	You do	15	55–70
7	Discussion	We do	10	70–80
8	Exit ticket / chapter quiz	You do	7	80–87
9	Closure	I do	3	87–90
	Total		**90**	

Syllabus

Week	Chapters	Lessons	Focus and activities	Assessment
1	*Introduction: author, context and reception* The Law of Life	2 × 90 min (180 min)	*the cycle of life and death* • Daily 90-minute lesson: bell-ringer, vocabulary and word histories, background, I do / We do / You do, discussion, exit ticket, closure • Story quizzes in the app • Introduction: author, context and reception • Writing prompt at assigned rigor (one graded per week)	Quiz average plus one graded writing prompt

Lesson plans and lecture scripts

Each chapter is one 90-minute class. Scripts are a starting point; adapt them to your students. Teacher summaries contain spoilers.

Lesson 1: Introduction to The Law of Life

Objective: Students will explain, in a 3-sentence exit ticket, how one fact about Jack London's life or times connects to the cycle of life and death in “The Law of Life”, and will set up a reading journal with a prediction and a question for each of 3 themes (the cycle of life and death, age and community, acceptance).

Standards: Common Core RL.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2

Author biography

Jack London was born in San Francisco on 12 January 1876 and grew up poor in Oakland, working in a cannery, as an oyster pirate and as a sailor, and riding the rails as a hobo. In 1897 he joined the Klondike Gold Rush in the Yukon; he found no gold but found his subject. The Call of the Wild (1903) made him one of the best-paid writers in the world. A socialist and adventurer, he wrote some 50 books before his death at his California ranch on 22 November 1916.

Historical and cultural context

The story depicts a nomadic Indigenous people of the Yukon, whom London portrays in the custom of leaving the frail elderly behind when the tribe moves on in winter. London's view is shaped by his reading of Darwin and Herbert Spencer.

Publication and reception, then and now

First published in McClure's Magazine in March 1901; collected in Children of the Frost (1902).

Then: Read as an exotic adventure tale.

Now: Taught as naturalism, and discussed critically for how it represents Indigenous people.

Overview (spoiler-free)

Old Koskoosh, blind and weak, is left by his tribe beside a small fire as they break camp, as custom demands.

Main themes

- the cycle of life and death.
- nature's indifference.
- acceptance.

Why it matters

It invites discussion of mortality and of whose perspective shapes stories about other cultures.

Spoilers · teacher only

He remembers watching an old moose brought down by wolves; as the fire dies, wolves close in and he accepts death.

Lesson plan (90 minutes)

0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)
Students write to the bell-ringer, then pair-share.
Before we open The Law of Life: Is it ever right for a group to leave someone behind?
Prompt: Before we open The Law of Life: Is it ever right for a group to leave someone behind?

8–18 min · Key terms · I do (10 min)
Key literary terms for the unit.
naturalism; flashback; symbol; interior monologue.

18–28 min · Mini-lecture: author, context, reception · I do (10 min)
Mini-lecture on the author, the historical context and the reception (read or adapt the script).
About the author. Jack London was born in San Francisco on 12 January 1876 and grew up poor in Oakland, working in a cannery, as an oyster pirate and as a sailor, and riding the rails as a hobo. In 1897 he joined the Klondike Gold Rush in the Yukon; he found no gold but found his subject. The Call of the Wild (1903) made him one of the best-paid writers in the world. A socialist and adventurer, he wrote some 50 books before his death at his California ranch on 22 November 1916. The world of the book. The story depicts a nomadic Indigenous people of the Yukon, whom London portrays in the custom of leaving the frail elderly behind when the tribe moves on in winter. London's view is shaped by his reading of Darwin and Herbert Spencer. Publication and reception. First published in McClure's Magazine in March 1901; collected in Children of the Frost (1902). Then: Read as an exotic adventure tale. Now: Taught as naturalism, and discussed critically for how it represents Indigenous people.

28–40 min · I do: the book in one passage · I do (12 min)
Model a close reading of one passage using the written think-aloud below.
First, meaning. I read "The thought made the old man panicky for the moment, and he stretched forth a palsied hand which wandered tremblingly over the small..." slowly and put it in my own words: The thought of death makes the old man panic for a moment, and he reaches with a shaking hand for the small pile of firewood. Next, craft. I notice the panic is quick and then the hand moves slowly, a contrast between fear and weakness. The strongest word is "tremblingly": it shows age, cold and fear all at once in his body. Then, effect. What does this sentence show about how Koskoosh faces death? My answer: Even though Koskoosh accepts the law that the old must die, his body grabs for life; London shows how hard acceptance really is.

> *The thought made the old man panicky for the moment, and he stretched forth a palsied hand which wandered tremblingly over the small heap of dry wood beside him.* *(The Law of Life, paragraph 2)*

Think-aloud: First, meaning. I read "The thought made the old man panicky for the moment, and he stretched forth a palsied hand which wandered tremblingly over the small…" slowly and put it in my own words: The thought of death makes the old man panic for a moment, and he reaches with a shaking hand for the small pile of firewood. Next, craft. I notice the panic is quick and then the hand moves slowly, a contrast between fear and weakness. The strongest word is "tremblingly": it shows age, cold and fear all at once in his body. Then, effect. What does this sentence show about how Koskoosh faces death? My answer: Even though Koskoosh accepts the law that the old must die, his body grabs for life; London shows how hard acceptance really is.

40–55 min · We do: overview and themes · We do (15 min)
Read the spoiler-free overview together and name the themes to track.
What the book is about (no spoilers): Old Koskoosh, blind and weak, is left by his tribe beside a small fire as they break camp, as custom demands. Themes to track: the cycle of life and death.: nature's indifference.: acceptance.:

55–70 min · You do: reading journal · You do (15 min)
Set up a reading journal: one page per theme, with a prediction and a question (example given).
Set up a reading journal: one page per theme with a prediction and a question. Page: age and community. Prediction: old Koskoosh, left by the fire as the tribe breaks camp, will reflect on the law that the old must make way for the young. Question: does he accept that law, and should we?
Task: Set up a reading journal for The Law of Life: one page per theme, each with a prediction and a question.
Exemplar: Page: age and community. Prediction: old Koskoosh, left by the fire as the tribe breaks camp, will reflect on the law that the old must make way for the young. Question: does he accept that law, and should we?

70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)
Whole-class discussion: why the book is still taught.
Why does The Law of Life still matter? It invites discussion of mortality and of whose perspective shapes stories about other cultures.
Anchor question: Why might The Law of Life still be taught today?
Facilitation: It invites discussion of mortality and of whose perspective shapes stories about other cultures.

80–87 min · Exit ticket · You do (7 min)
Exit ticket on the author and context (answer given).
London spent a year in the Klondike during the 1897 gold rush. What did he learn there that he uses in this story? Answer: Accept answers such as: how cold and hunger shape survival; the harsh logic of nature; he heard stories of northern peoples and their customs.
Exit ticket: London spent a year in the Klondike during the 1897 gold rush. What did he learn there that he uses in this story?
Answer: Accept answers such as: how cold and hunger shape survival; the harsh logic of nature; he heard stories of northern peoples and their customs.

87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)
Preview the first reading.
Tomorrow we begin reading: The Law of Life.

Teacher notes · sources: Jack London State Historic Park, "Jack London" (https://jacklondonpark.com/jack-london/); Britannica, "Jack London" (https://www.britannica.com/biography/Jack-London); Jack London Online Collection (Sonoma State University) (https://london.sonoma.edu/)

Flags (verify before teaching):

- The depiction of the custom is London's fiction; do not present it as accurate ethnography of any specific nation.

Lesson 2: The Law of Life

Focus: accepting one's place in nature's cycle

Objective: Students will analyze how setting develops in “The Law of Life” by writing a claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph that cites at least 2 quotations from the section, and will score at least 80% on the section quiz.

Standards: Common Core RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1, L.9-10.4

Content note (an elder left to die, wolves, a period ethnic slur for an indigenous woman): Sensitive content: An elder left to die; wolves; a period ethnic slur for an Indigenous woman. Preview the story, tell students in advance, and allow a pass on reading aloud. Keep discussion on how the writer uses these elements, not on graphic detail. The text quotes racial slurs in period dialogue: decide in advance that no one reads them aloud, and name why the author records them.
Student preview: Heads-up: this story includes an elder left to die; wolves; a period ethnic slur for an Indigenous woman.
Suggested language: “Why does the writer include this, and what does it make us notice?”

Teacher only · spoilers

Old Koskoosh, blind and frail, is left by his tribe beside a small fire with a pile of sticks as they move camp in the Arctic winter, as custom requires. He remembers the old moose he once watched wolves bring down and accepts that nature cares only for the race, not the individual. When his fire dies, wolves close in; he lets the firebrand fall.

Background: Published in McClure's in 1901 and collected in Children of the Frost (1902). London draws on, and generalizes, accounts of Indigenous Yukon peoples; teachers should discuss this outsider's perspective.

Significance: A compact statement of London's naturalism, paired often with To Build a Fire.

Lesson plan and lecture script (90 minutes)

0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)
Students write to the bell-ringer, then pair-share.
How should a community care for its oldest members? Write for five minutes. Starters: I think... because... / This connects to the cycle of life and death because.... Content note before we start: Heads-up: this story includes an elder left to die; wolves; a period ethnic slur for an Indigenous woman.
Prompt: How should a community care for its oldest members?
Sentence starters: I think… because… · This connects to the cycle of life and death because…
Strong response: A strong response takes a position and anticipates this: the individual is nothing to nature.

8–18 min · Vocabulary with etymology notes · I do (10 min)
Four key words in context, with verified word histories.
Today's words: retreated — pull back or move away or backward; footing — a firm placing of the feet; a foothold; obedient — dutifully complying with the commands or instructions of those in authority; wonders — marvels; strange, astonishing events. "obedient": Origin: Old French obedient; earlier Latin oboediēns.
Words: retreated: pull back or move away or backward · footing: a firm placing of the feet; a foothold · obedient: dutifully complying with the commands or instructions of those in authority · wonders: marvels; strange, astonishing events

18–28 min · Background and context · I do (10 min)
Mini-lecture (read or adapt the script).
Published in McClure's in 1901 and collected in Children of the Frost (1902). London draws on, and generalizes, accounts of Indigenous Yukon peoples; teachers should discuss this outsider's perspective. A compact statement of London's naturalism, paired often with To Build a Fire. Point of view: Limited to Koskoosh; we hear what he hears, since he is blind. Flashback: The moose hunt. Symbolism: The fire and its sticks measure his remaining life. Watch for the fire: life running out.

28–40 min · I do: modeled close reading · I do (12 min)
Model the close reading of the anchor quotation using the written think-aloud below.
First, meaning. I read "Old Koskoosh listened greedily" slowly and put it in my own words: Old, blind Koskoosh listens hard to every sound of the camp as it packs up to leave him. Next, craft. I notice the word "greedily," normally used for food, used here for sound. The strongest word is "greedily": it shows he is hungry for the last signs of his people because hearing is all he has left. Then, effect. Why does Koskoosh listen so greedily? My answer: Koskoosh listens so greedily because hearing is the last tie he has to his departing tribe and to life; the line shows his loneliness and fear as he is left behind to die.

> *Old Koskoosh listened greedily (The Law of Life, paragraph 1)*

Think-aloud: First, meaning. I read "Old Koskoosh listened greedily" slowly and put it in my own words: Old, blind Koskoosh listens hard to every sound of the camp as it packs up to leave him. Next, craft. I notice the word "greedily," normally used for food, used here for sound. The strongest word is "greedily": it shows he is hungry for the last signs of his people because hearing is all he has left. Then, effect. Why does Koskoosh listen so greedily? My answer: Koskoosh listens so greedily because hearing is the last tie he has to his departing tribe and to life; the line shows his loneliness and fear as he is left behind to die.

40–55 min · We do: guided annotation · We do (15 min)
Guided analysis of a second quotation; expected answers given.
Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest? Expected: Personifying nature as not caring shows the naturalist view of an indifferent universe. Ask: How does this line connect to the cycle of life and death? Expected: The individual is nothing to nature. (Theme.)

> *Nature did not care (The Law of Life, paragraph 18)*

Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest?
Expected answer: Personifying nature as not caring shows the naturalist view of an indifferent universe.
Ask: How does this line connect to the cycle of life and death?
Expected answer: The individual is nothing to nature. (Theme.)

55–70 min · You do: independent annotation · You do (15 min)
Independent annotation and a claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph (exemplar given).
Annotate the story for point of view, flashback (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this story suggest about accepting one's place in nature's cycle? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how The Law of Life develops the idea of accepting one's place in nature's cycle. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of setting and theme shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.)
Exemplar: Koskoosh accepts death because he sees it as nature's law. When the text says “Nature did not care” (The Law of Life, paragraph 18), it shows this directly. He reflects that "Nature did not care" for the individual and that "It was the law of all flesh," so he does not fight the wolves.
Task: Annotate the story for point of view, flashback (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this story suggest about accepting one's place in nature's cycle? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how The Law of Life develops the idea of accepting one's place in nature's cycle. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of setting and theme shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.)
Exemplar: Koskoosh accepts death because he sees it as nature's law. When the text says “Nature did not care” (The Law of Life, paragraph 18), it shows this directly. He reflects that "Nature did not care" for the individual and that "It was the law of all flesh," so he does not fight the wolves.

70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)
Structured discussion from the 30 tiered questions, with facilitation notes.
Anchor question: How should a community care for its oldest members? Ask: is acceptance the same as surrender?
Anchor question: How should a community care for its oldest members?
Facilitation: Ask: is acceptance the same as surrender?

80–87 min · Exit ticket / chapter quiz · You do (7 min)
Story quiz in the app and an exit ticket (answer given).
Story quiz in the app, then: In one sentence, what does this story suggest about accepting one's place in nature's cycle? Support it with one short quotation. Model answer: Koskoosh accepts death because he sees it as nature's law. ("Nature did not care", The Law of Life, paragraph 18). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the story; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.
Exit ticket: In one sentence, what does this story suggest about accepting one's place in nature's cycle? Support it with one short quotation.
Answer: Model answer: Koskoosh accepts death because he sees it as nature's law. ("Nature did not care", The Law of Life, paragraph 18). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the story; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.

87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)
Summarize the lesson and preview the next reading.
Today we saw how point of view shapes accepting one's place in nature's cycle. Key takeaway: the individual is nothing to nature.

Total: 90 minutes.

Teacher analysis (spoilers)

Literary elements

- **Point of view:** Limited to Koskoosh; we hear what he hears, since he is blind.
- **Flashback:** The moose hunt.
- **Symbolism:** The fire and its sticks measure his remaining life.

Themes and how they develop

- **the cycle of life and death:** the individual is nothing to nature.

Symbols and motifs

- **the fire:** life running out.

Key quotations (checked against the reading text)

- "Old Koskoosh listened greedily" (The Law of Life, paragraph 1) Sound.
- "Nature did not care" (The Law of Life, paragraph 18) Theme.
- "It was the law of all flesh" (The Law of Life, paragraph 18) Acceptance.

Model claim-evidence-reasoning

Claim: Koskoosh accepts death because he sees it as nature's law.
Evidence: "Nature did not care" (The Law of Life, paragraph 18)

Reasoning: He reflects that "Nature did not care" for the individual and that "It was the law of all flesh," so he does not fight the wolves.

Vocabulary with etymology notes

Word	Definition (in this sentence)	In context	Word history
retreated (verb)	pull back or move away or backward	*Overcome for the nonce by his hereditary fear of man, the brute retreated, raising a prolonged call to his brothers; and greedily they answered, till a ring of crouching, jaw-slobbered gray was stretched round about.*	
footing (noun)	a firm placing of the feet; a foothold	*Twice had he been dragged down, as the snow attested, and twice had he shaken his assailants clear and gained footing once more.*	
obedient (adjective)	dutifully complying with the commands or instructions of those in authority	*Nature did not care; there were plenty who were obedient, and it was only the obedience in this matter, not the obedient, which lived and lived always.*	“obedient”: Origin: Old French obedient; earlier Latin oboediēns. (Liber et Libri origin note, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/obedient#Etymology)
wonders (noun)	marvels; strange, astonishing events	*The shaman would see signs and wonders in this when they told him.*	

Discussion questions

1. How should a community care for its oldest members?
2. Where does setting appear in this story, and what effect does it have? Point to one passage.
3. How does this story connect to the book's larger concern with the cycle of life and death?

Classroom discussion questions (30, tiered)

Wait time after every question (3 s for DOK 1, 5 s for DOK 2, 8 to 10 s for DOK 3 and 4); think-pair-share on DOK 3 and 4; answer each response with a follow-up probe; close with student-generated questions. Focus sets by rigor level: Scaffolded support: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 11, 12, 13, 14, 21, 22; HS Freshman: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 12, 13, 14, 15, 22, 23, 24; HS Sophomore: 1, 2, 3, 4, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 23, 24, 25; HS Junior: 1, 2, 3, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18, 24, 25, 26, 27; HS Senior: 1, 2, 3, 15, 16, 17, 18, 25, 26, 27, 28, 29; AP: 1, 2, 16, 17, 18, 19, 20, 26, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Freshman: 1, 2, 17, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Sophomore: 1, 2, 11, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 28, 29, 30; College Junior: 1, 11, 12, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 29, 30; College Senior: 1, 11, 12, 13, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 30; Graduate / PhD: 1, 11, 12, 13, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 27, 28

Literal / recall

1. Why is Koskoosh left behind? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: He is too old and weak to travel with the tribe

2. What is left with him? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: A small fire and a pile of sticks
3. Who leads the tribe now? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: His son, the chief
4. What memory does Koskoosh recall? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Wolves bringing down an old moose
5. What does 'the law of life' mean in the story? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Nature cares for the race, not the individual
6. Retell the three most important events of “The Law of Life” in order, in one sentence each. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Old Koskoosh, blind and frail, is left by his tribe beside a small fire with a pile of sticks as they move camp in the Arctic winter, as custom requires. He remembers the old moose he once watched wolves bring down and accepts that nature cares only for the race, not the individual. When his fire dies, wolves close in; he lets the firebrand fall.
7. Which characters appear or are mentioned in “The Law of Life”? Name two and one thing each says or does. [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Names and actions taken from the story; check against the teacher summary.
8. Where and when does “The Law of Life” take place? Point to the line that tells you. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: A place/time detail quoted from the story.
9. Reread: “Overcome for the nonce by his hereditary fear of man, the brute retreated, raising a prolonged call to his brothers; and greedily they answered, till a ring of crouching, jaw-slobbered gray was stretched round about.” What does “retreated” mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: retreated: pull back or move away or backward.
10. Reread: “Twice had he been dragged down, as the snow attested, and twice had he shaken his assailants clear and gained footing once more.” What does “footing” mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: footing: a firm placing of the feet; a foothold.

Inferential / analytical

1. What does “The Law of Life” suggest about accepting one's place in nature's cycle? State the inference and the line that supports it. [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A compact statement of London's naturalism, paired often with To Build a Fire.
2. Find one example of setting in this story. What does it reveal that a plain statement would not? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: Look for where and when events happen and how place shapes action or feeling.
3. How does the theme in this story shape what we understand about accepting one's place in nature's cycle? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: Look for statements or moments that connect to the book's big ideas.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Koskoosh accepts death because he sees it as nature's law. Useful evidence: “Old Koskoosh listened greedily” (The Law of Life, paragraph 1): Sound. Theme link: the individual is nothing to nature. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

4. In the passage that begins “Again, they ceased the uplift of their snowshoes at a second stand.”, why might London have chosen these particular words? Pick two and explain their connotations. [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.4, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.4] Look for: Diction analysis of two words in the anchor passage.
5. What causes the main turn in “The Law of Life”, and what effect is it likely to have on what follows? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: Old Koskoosh, blind and frail, is left by his tribe beside a small fire with a pile of sticks as they move camp in the Arctic winter, as custom requires. He remembers the old moose he once watched wolves bring down and accepts that nature cares only for the race, not the individual. When his fire…
6. As the opening story, what does “The Law of Life” set up that the rest of The Law of Life will need? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: A causal or structural link between this and the previous story.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Koskoosh accepts death because he sees it as nature's law. Useful evidence: “Nature did not care” (The Law of Life, paragraph 18): Theme. Theme link: the individual is nothing to nature. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
7. What can we infer about a character's motives from what they say and do here, as opposed to what they claim? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: An inference about motive supported by a quoted line.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Koskoosh accepts death because he sees it as nature's law. Useful evidence: “It was the law of all flesh” (The Law of Life, paragraph 18): Acceptance. Theme link: the individual is nothing to nature. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
8. The bell-ringer asked: “How should a community care for its oldest members?” Now that we have read closely, how would you revise your first answer, and which line changed your mind? [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A revised answer anchored in the text.
9. Where does imagery appear, and how does it connect this story to the larger concern with the cycle of life and death? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.4, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.4] Look for: Look for sensory details (sight, sound, cold, light) and what mood they create.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Koskoosh accepts death because he sees it as nature's law. Useful evidence: “Old Koskoosh listened greedily” (The Law of Life, paragraph 1): Sound. Theme link: the individual is nothing to nature. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
10. Background: Published in McClure's in 1901 and collected in Children of the Frost (1902). London draws on, and generalizes, accounts of Indigenous Yukon peoples; teachers should discuss this outsider's perspective. How does knowing this change the way you read one moment in the story? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: A specific moment reread in light of the context.

    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Koskoosh accepts death because he sees it as nature's law. Useful evidence: “Nature did not care” (The Law of Life, paragraph 18): Theme. Theme link: the individual is nothing to nature. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Evaluative / synthesis / creative

1. A critic might argue: “A compact statement of London's naturalism, paired often with To Build a Fire.” How far do you agree? Take a stand and defend it with two lines from the story. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s

· RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A defended position with evidence and one counterpoint.

Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Koskoosh accepts death because he sees it as nature's law. Useful evidence: “It was the law of all flesh” (The Law of Life, paragraph 18): Acceptance. Theme link: the individual is nothing to nature. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

2. Which character in this story acts most wisely, and which least? Judge them by a standard you name. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: An evaluation using an explicit criterion and evidence.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Koskoosh accepts death because he sees it as nature's law. Useful evidence: “Old Koskoosh listened greedily” (The Law of Life, paragraph 1): Sound. Theme link: the individual is nothing to nature. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

3. Rewrite one moment of “The Law of Life” from the point of view of a different character. What does the new angle reveal or hide about accepting one's place in nature's cycle? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.6] Look for: A creative product with a rationale tied to the text.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Koskoosh accepts death because he sees it as nature's law. Useful evidence: “Nature did not care” (The Law of Life, paragraph 18): Theme. On point of view: Limited to Koskoosh; we hear what he hears, since he is blind. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

4. Write three questions of your own about “The Law of Life”: one recall, one “why/how”, and one “should/what if”. Trade with a partner and answer theirs. [DOK 3 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: Student-generated questions at three levels.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Koskoosh accepts death because he sees it as nature's law. Useful evidence: “It was the law of all flesh” (The Law of Life, paragraph 18): Acceptance. Theme link: the individual is nothing to nature. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

5. Connect this story to age and community: is the link strong or weak so far? What would London need to show next to strengthen it? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A judgment of thematic development across the work.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Koskoosh accepts death because he sees it as nature's law. Useful evidence: “Old Koskoosh listened greedily” (The Law of Life, paragraph 1): Sound. Theme link: the individual is nothing to nature. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

6. Is the setting in this story effective, or does it feel heavy-handed? Evaluate it as a reader would in a review. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: An evaluative judgment with criteria and evidence.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Koskoosh accepts death because he sees it as nature's law. Useful evidence: “Nature did not care” (The Law of Life, paragraph 18): Theme. Theme link: the individual is nothing to nature. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

7. Compare how “The Law of Life” treats accepting one's place in nature's cycle with how another text, film or event you know treats a similar idea. What does The Law of Life see that the other misses? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A cross-text synthesis.

Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Koskoosh accepts death because he sees it as nature's law. Useful evidence: “It was the law of all flesh” (The Law of Life, paragraph 18): Acceptance. Theme link: the individual is nothing to nature. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

8. As the final story, does this ending resolve the cycle of life and death? Argue whether the ending is earned. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: A prediction or judgment justified with textual clues.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Koskoosh accepts death because he sees it as nature's law. Useful evidence: “Old Koskoosh listened greedily” (The Law of Life, paragraph 1): Sound. Theme link: the individual is nothing to nature. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

9. Design a one-paragraph modern adaptation of this story (setting, characters, conflict). What must stay the same for it to still be about accepting one's place in nature's cycle? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A creative transfer that keeps the core idea.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Koskoosh accepts death because he sees it as nature's law. Useful evidence: “Nature did not care” (The Law of Life, paragraph 18): Theme. Theme link: the individual is nothing to nature. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

10. What question would you most like to ask Jack London about this story, and what answer do you think the text itself gives? [DOK 4 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A student-generated question answered from evidence.

    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Koskoosh accepts death because he sees it as nature's law. Useful evidence: “It was the law of all flesh” (The Law of Life, paragraph 18): Acceptance. Theme link: the individual is nothing to nature. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Annotation focus

- **Setting:** look for where and when events happen and how place shapes action or feeling (anchor passage in the We do segment)
- Also notice **Theme**: statements or moments that connect to the book's big ideas
- Also notice **Imagery**: sensory details (sight, sound, cold, light) and what mood they create

Chapter quiz: item bank (all eleven rigor versions)

1. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What memory does Koskoosh recall?

   A. His wedding

   B. His first trade

   C. Wolves bringing down an old moose

   D. A great flood

   Key: C (Wolves bringing down an old moose)

2. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What does 'the law of life' mean in the story?

   A. Nature cares for the race, not the individual

   B. Fire protects life

C. Never be alone

D. Always obey the chief

Key: A (Nature cares for the race, not the individual)

3. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: "Overcome for the nonce by his hereditary fear of man, the brute _____, raising a prolonged call to his brothers; and greedily they answered, till a ring of crouching, jaw-slobbered gray was stretched round about." Word bank: wonders, retreated, obedient, footing

   Key: retreated

4. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: "Twice had he been dragged down, as the snow attested, and twice had he shaken his assailants clear and gained _____ once more." Word bank: retreated, footing, wonders, obedient

   Key: footing

5. [mc · recall · DOK 1] Why is Koskoosh left behind?

   A. He chooses to hunt

   B. He is sick with plague

   C. He is too old and weak to travel with the tribe

   D. He is being punished

   Key: C (He is too old and weak to travel with the tribe)

6. [mc · recall · DOK 1] Who leads the tribe now?

   A. His granddaughter

   B. A shaman

   C. His son, the chief

   D. A trader

   Key: C (His son, the chief)

7. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What is left with him?

   A. Food for a month

   B. A rifle

   C. A small fire and a pile of sticks

   D. A sled

   Key: C (A small fire and a pile of sticks)

8. [short · inference · DOK 2] What can you infer from this line? "Nature did not care" (The Law of Life, paragraph 18) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

   Sample answer: Theme.

9. [short · inference · DOK 2] What can you infer from this line? "Old Koskoosh listened greedily" (The Law of Life, paragraph 1) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

   Sample answer: Sound.

10. [mc · inference · DOK 2] Which choice best states a central concern of "The Law of Life"?

    A. The hunter becoming the hunted

    B. Friendship tested by duty

    C. A crime that backfires

D. Accepting one's place in nature's cycle

Key: D (Accepting one's place in nature's cycle)

11. [short · analysis · DOK 3] Analyze the word choice in “It was the law of all flesh” (The Law of Life, paragraph 18). Pick two words and explain what they suggest.
    Sample answer: Acceptance.
12. [mc · analysis · DOK 3] Which literary element does this describe in “The Law of Life”? Limited to Koskoosh; we hear what he hears, since he is blind.
    A. Alliteration
    B. Point of view
    C. Simile
    D. Irony

    Key: B (Point of view)
13. [short · analysis · DOK 3] Claim: Koskoosh accepts death because he sees it as nature's law. Explain how this evidence supports the claim: “Nature did not care” (The Law of Life, paragraph 18).
    Sample answer: He reflects that "Nature did not care" for the individual and that "It was the law of all flesh," so he does not fight the wolves.
14. [mc · analysis · DOK 3] Which literary element does this describe in “The Law of Life”? The moose hunt.
    A. Alliteration
    B. Flashback
    C. Conflict
    D. Point of view

    Key: B (Flashback)
15. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Evaluate this claim about the story: “Koskoosh accepts death because he sees it as nature's law.” Is it fully persuasive? Argue with evidence, including a passage that complicates it.
    Sample answer: He reflects that "Nature did not care" for the individual and that "It was the law of all flesh," so he does not fight the wolves.
16. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Synthesis: trace how the cycle of life and death develops from an earlier story to “The Law of Life”. Use one quotation from each.
    Sample answer: the individual is nothing to nature.
17. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “Old Koskoosh listened greedily” (The Law of Life, paragraph 1) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.
    Sample answer: Sound.
18. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “Nature did not care” (The Law of Life, paragraph 18) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.
    Sample answer: Theme.
19. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “The shaman would see signs and wonders in this when they told him.”, what does “wonders” most nearly mean?
    A. a firm placing of the feet; a foothold
    B. marvels; strange, astonishing events
    C. dutifully complying with the commands or instructions of those in authority
    D. pull back or move away or backward

Key: B (marvels; strange, astonishing events)

20. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “Nature did not care; there were plenty who were obedient, and it was only the obedience in this matter, not the obedient, which lived and lived always.”, what does “obedient” most nearly mean?

    A. a firm placing of the feet; a foothold

    B. dutifully complying with the commands or instructions of those in authority

    C. pull back or move away or backward

    D. marvels; strange, astonishing events

    Key: B (dutifully complying with the commands or instructions of those in authority)

21. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “Overcome for the nonce by his hereditary fear of man, the brute retreated, raising a prolonged call to his brothers; and greedily they answered, till a ring of crouching, jaw-slobbered gray was stretched round about.”, what does “retreated” most nearly mean?

    A. marvels; strange, astonishing events

    B. dutifully complying with the commands or instructions of those in authority

    C. pull back or move away or backward

    D. a firm placing of the feet; a foothold

    Key: C (pull back or move away or backward)

22. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “Twice had he been dragged down, as the snow attested, and twice had he shaken his assailants clear and gained footing once more.”, what does “footing” most nearly mean?

    A. a firm placing of the feet; a foothold

    B. marvels; strange, astonishing events

    C. dutifully complying with the commands or instructions of those in authority

    D. pull back or move away or backward

    Key: A (a firm placing of the feet; a foothold)

Rigor version	Items (in order)	Mix
Scaffolded support	1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 7, 8, 9, 10, 11, 12, 13, 14, 15, 16	recall 7, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 2
HS Freshman	7, 5, 2, 3, 6, 1, 4, 10, 8, 9, 14, 11, 12, 13, 15, 17	recall 7, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 2
HS Sophomore	3, 5, 6, 1, 2, 4, 7, 8, 9, 10, 13, 12, 14, 11, 15, 18	recall 7, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 2
HS Junior	1, 7, 5, 4, 6, 2, 3, 10, 9, 8, 14, 12, 13, 11, 18, 15	recall 7, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 2
HS Senior	1, 4, 2, 5, 7, 3, 9, 10, 8, 11, 12, 13, 14, 18, 16, 17	recall 6, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 3
AP	3, 7, 4, 1, 6, 8, 10, 9, 11, 12, 14, 13, 15, 18, 17, 16	recall 5, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
College Freshman	3, 4, 5, 19, 1, 9, 10, 8, 13, 14, 11, 12, 15, 18, 16, 17	recall 5, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
College Sophomore	3, 4, 6, 7, 19, 9, 10, 8, 12, 13, 14, 11, 15, 16, 17, 18	recall 5, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
College Junior	3, 4, 6, 2, 20, 9, 10, 8, 12, 14, 13, 11, 17, 16, 18, 15	recall 5, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
College Senior	3, 4, 1, 21, 20, 9, 10, 8, 14, 13, 12, 11, 16, 18, 17, 15	recall 5, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
Graduate / PhD	3, 4, 5, 22, 6, 8, 9, 10, 12, 14, 11, 13, 16, 15, 18, 17	recall 5, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4

Writing prompts (eleven rigor levels)

Scaffolded support (250 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1): Supported track (work from the passage your teacher selects). In “The Law of Life,” how does London show accepting one's place in nature's cycle? Write a paragraph that states your claim, quotes two details from the passage, and explains how each detail supports your idea. Use the setting you noticed as one piece of evidence.

HS Freshman (350 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1): In The Law of Life, how does London develop the idea of accepting one's place in nature's cycle? State a clear claim, support it with two or three quotations, and explain how the setting in the story helps build that idea.

HS Sophomore (450 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1): Analyze how The Law of Life develops the idea of accepting one's place in nature's cycle. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of setting and theme shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.

HS Junior (550 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.5, RL.11-12.1, W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.9): Analyze how the structure of The Law of Life (where it begins, turns and ends) and its setting shape the reader's understanding of accepting one's place in nature's cycle. Identify one place where the text leaves matters uncertain and explain how that uncertainty adds to its meaning.

HS Senior (600 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.3, W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.9): Two readers disagree about what The Law of Life suggests about accepting one's place in nature's cycle. Lay out two plausible interpretations, weigh the evidence for each (including the story's setting and theme), and argue for the stronger one in a sustained, well-organized essay.

AP (650 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.3, W.11-12.1): Write a literary argument in which you analyze how Jack London uses setting in The Law of Life to complicate the reader's understanding of accepting one's place in nature's cycle. Develop a defensible thesis, select evidence purposefully, and explain how specific choices of diction and syntax create meaning.

College Freshman (1000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Situate The Law of Life within its historical and literary context and argue how the story's treatment of accepting one's place in nature's cycle responds to that context. Engage with at least one secondary perspective (a critic, historian or the author's own statements), integrate quotations smoothly, and cite in MLA style.

College Sophomore (1250 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Read The Law of Life alongside the conventions of its genre and period. Argue how the story's handling of accepting one's place in nature's cycle follows or bends those conventions, using the setting as evidence, and test your reading against one published critic. Document two secondary sources in MLA.

College Junior (1500 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Apply a named critical approach (for example formalist, historicist, feminist, psychoanalytic or ecocritical) to The Law of Life and its treatment of accepting one's place in nature's cycle. State your method, show what it reveals in the story's setting and theme, and identify where the text resists it.

College Senior (2000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Develop a research argument that reads The Law of Life as evidence for a larger claim about accepting one's place in nature's cycle in The Law of Life. Connect close reading of the story to the whole story, engage at least four scholarly sources, and state precisely where your reading departs from theirs (Chicago style).

Graduate / PhD (2500 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Develop an original argument that reads The Law of Life as a hinge in the story's larger treatment of accepting one's place in nature's cycle. Position your reading within a named critical conversation (for example formalist, historicist, psychoanalytic, feminist or postcolonial approaches), account for the textual history where relevant, and articulate the stakes of your intervention for scholarship on The Law of Life.

SAT-style questions

1. *Overcome for the nonce by his hereditary fear of man, the brute retreated, raising a prolonged call to his brothers; and greedily they answered, till a ring of crouching, jaw-slobbered gray was stretched round about.*

   As used in the text, what does the word “retreated” most nearly mean?

   A. pull back or move away or backward

   B. dutifully complying with the commands or instructions of those in authority

   C. a firm placing of the feet; a foothold

   D. marvels; strange, astonishing events

2. *Again, they ceased the uplift of their snowshoes at a second stand. Here the great animal had fought desperately. Twice had he been dragged down, as the snow attested, and twice had he shaken his assailants clear and gained footing once more. He had done his task long since, but none the less was life dear to him. Zing-ha said it was a strange thing, a moose once down to get free again; but this one certainly had. The shaman would see signs and wonders in this when they told him.*

   Which choice best states a central concern of “The Law of Life”?

   A. Revenge carried out with perfect control

   B. A choice the reader must make

   C. Endurance turning to justice

   D. Accepting one's place in nature's cycle

SAT key: 1. A (pull back or move away or backward); 2. D (Accepting one's place in nature's cycle)

Unit test

The Law of Life: end test · 90 minutes · 18 questions per rigor version (multiple choice, fill in the blank, short answer). The class rigor level picks the version; student auto-adjust applies.

Short-answer scoring guides

Scaffolded support and HS Freshman (2 points): correct answer in a complete sentence with a detail from the text. HS Sophomore to HS Senior (3 points): claim, one accurate quotation, one sentence of explanation. AP to College Sophomore (4 points): precise claim, two embedded quotations, commentary on word choice or structure, link to theme. College Junior to Graduate (5 points): nuanced thesis, close reading of two passages, synthesis across sections, a competing reading answered. Each item lists a sample answer; partial credit is described in the app.

Unit test: item bank (all eleven rigor versions)

1. [mc · recall · DOK 1] Who leads the tribe now?
   A. His granddaughter
   B. A shaman
   C. His son, the chief
   D. A trader

   Key: C (His son, the chief)
2. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “Twice had he been dragged down, as the snow attested, and twice had he shaken his assailants clear and gained _____ once more.” Word bank: retreated, footing, wonders, obedient

   Key: footing
3. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What is left with him?
   A. Food for a month
   B. A rifle
   C. A small fire and a pile of sticks
   D. A sled

   Key: C (A small fire and a pile of sticks)
4. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What memory does Koskoosh recall?
   A. His wedding
   B. His first trade
   C. Wolves bringing down an old moose
   D. A great flood

   Key: C (Wolves bringing down an old moose)
5. [mc · recall · DOK 1] Why is Koskoosh left behind?
   A. He chooses to hunt
   B. He is sick with plague
   C. He is too old and weak to travel with the tribe

D. He is being punished

Key: C (He is too old and weak to travel with the tribe)

6. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What does 'the law of life' mean in the story?

   A. Nature cares for the race, not the individual

   B. Fire protects life

   C. Never be alone

   D. Always obey the chief

   Key: A (Nature cares for the race, not the individual)

7. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “Overcome for the nonce by his hereditary fear of man, the brute _____, raising a prolonged call to his brothers; and greedily they answered, till a ring of crouching, jaw-slobbered gray was stretched round about.” Word bank: wonders, retreated, obedient, footing

   Key: retreated

8. [mc · inference · DOK 2] Which choice best states a central concern of “The Law of Life”?

   A. The hunter becoming the hunted

   B. Friendship tested by duty

   C. A crime that backfires

   D. Accepting one's place in nature's cycle

   Key: D (Accepting one's place in nature's cycle)

9. [short · inference · DOK 2] What can you infer from this line? “Nature did not care” (The Law of Life, paragraph 18) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

   Sample answer: Theme.

10. [short · inference · DOK 2] What can you infer from this line? “Old Koskoosh listened greedily” (The Law of Life, paragraph 1) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: Sound.

11. [short · analysis · DOK 3] Analyze the word choice in “It was the law of all flesh” (The Law of Life, paragraph 18). Pick two words and explain what they suggest.

    Sample answer: Acceptance.

12. [mc · analysis · DOK 3] Which literary element does this describe in “The Law of Life”? Limited to Koskoosh; we hear what he hears, since he is blind.

    A. Alliteration

    B. Point of view

    C. Simile

    D. Irony

    Key: B (Point of view)

13. [mc · analysis · DOK 3] Which literary element does this describe in “The Law of Life”? The moose hunt.

    A. Alliteration

    B. Flashback

    C. Conflict

    D. Point of view

Key: B (Flashback)

14. [short · analysis · DOK 3] Claim: Koskoosh accepts death because he sees it as nature's law. Explain how this evidence supports the claim: “Nature did not care” (The Law of Life, paragraph 18).
    Sample answer: He reflects that "Nature did not care" for the individual and that "It was the law of all flesh," so he does not fight the wolves.
15. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Evaluate this claim about the story: “Koskoosh accepts death because he sees it as nature's law.” Is it fully persuasive? Argue with evidence, including a passage that complicates it.
    Sample answer: He reflects that "Nature did not care" for the individual and that "It was the law of all flesh," so he does not fight the wolves.
16. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “Nature did not care” (The Law of Life, paragraph 18) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.
    Sample answer: Theme.
17. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Synthesis: trace how the cycle of life and death develops from an earlier story to “The Law of Life”. Use one quotation from each.
    Sample answer: the individual is nothing to nature.
18. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “Old Koskoosh listened greedily” (The Law of Life, paragraph 1) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.
    Sample answer: Sound.
19. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “The shaman would see signs and wonders in this when they told him.”, what does “wonders” most nearly mean?
    A. a firm placing of the feet; a foothold
    B. marvels; strange, astonishing events
    C. dutifully complying with the commands or instructions of those in authority
    D. pull back or move away or backward

    Key: B (marvels; strange, astonishing events)
20. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “Overcome for the nonce by his hereditary fear of man, the brute retreated, raising a prolonged call to his brothers; and greedily they answered, till a ring of crouching, jaw-slobbered gray was stretched round about.”, what does “retreated” most nearly mean?
    A. marvels; strange, astonishing events
    B. dutifully complying with the commands or instructions of those in authority
    C. pull back or move away or backward
    D. a firm placing of the feet; a foothold

    Key: C (pull back or move away or backward)
21. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “Twice had he been dragged down, as the snow attested, and twice had he shaken his assailants clear and gained footing once more.”, what does “footing” most nearly mean?
    A. a firm placing of the feet; a foothold
    B. marvels; strange, astonishing events
    C. dutifully complying with the commands or instructions of those in authority
    D. pull back or move away or backward

    Key: A (a firm placing of the feet; a foothold)

22. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “Nature did not care; there were plenty who were obedient, and it was only the obedience in this matter, not the obedient, which lived and lived always.”, what does “obedient” most nearly mean?

    A. a firm placing of the feet; a foothold

    B. dutifully complying with the commands or instructions of those in authority

    C. pull back or move away or backward

    D. marvels; strange, astonishing events

    Key: B (dutifully complying with the commands or instructions of those in authority)

Rigor version	Items (in order)	Mix
Scaffolded support	1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 7, 8, 9, 10, 11, 12, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18	recall 7, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
HS Freshman	7, 5, 3, 2, 6, 1, 4, 10, 9, 8, 11, 12, 13, 14, 18, 16, 17, 15	recall 7, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
HS Sophomore	6, 4, 7, 1, 2, 5, 3, 10, 9, 8, 13, 12, 11, 14, 17, 18, 16, 15	recall 7, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
HS Junior	4, 2, 7, 5, 3, 6, 1, 8, 9, 10, 11, 12, 13, 14, 15, 18, 17, 16	recall 7, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
HS Senior	2, 1, 6, 7, 5, 4, 3, 10, 8, 9, 14, 13, 11, 12, 16, 18, 17, 15	recall 7, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
AP	1, 7, 4, 19, 2, 20, 21, 8, 9, 10, 11, 13, 12, 14, 18, 16, 15, 17	recall 7, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
College Freshman	2, 6, 22, 5, 21, 7, 3, 8, 10, 9, 14, 11, 12, 13, 15, 18, 16, 17	recall 7, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
College Sophomore	7, 3, 4, 20, 5, 6, 2, 9, 8, 10, 11, 13, 12, 14, 17, 18, 15, 16	recall 7, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
College Junior	2, 19, 7, 3, 5, 6, 4, 8, 9, 10, 12, 11, 13, 14, 16, 15, 17, 18	recall 7, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
College Senior	7, 2, 20, 21, 22, 3, 5, 9, 8, 10, 11, 13, 12, 14, 18, 16, 17, 15	recall 7, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
Graduate / PhD	7, 2, 3, 4, 19, 5, 22, 10, 9, 8, 13, 11, 14, 12, 15, 18, 16, 17	recall 7, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4

Final paper

The Law of Life: final paper (formal literary analysis). Choose one prompt.

1. Analyze how Jack London develops the cycle of life and death across The Law of Life. Trace the idea through at least three moments (beginning, middle and end) and argue what the ending finally suggests.
2. Choose one recurring symbol, image or motif in The Law of Life and argue how its meaning changes over the story and why that change matters to age and community.
3. Analyze a central character's choices in The Law of Life. Argue whether the story judges that character, and how its structure or point of view shapes your answer.
4. Two readers disagree about whether The Law of Life finally endorses or criticizes its society's view of acceptance. Weigh both readings and argue for one, answering the strongest objection.

Length: Scaffolded support 500-700 words; HS Freshman 700-900 words; HS Sophomore 900-1,100 words; HS Junior 1,000-1,300 words; HS Senior 1,200-1,500 words; AP 1,300-1,600 words; College Freshman 1,500-2,000 words; College Sophomore 2,000-2,500 words; College Junior 2,500-3,000 words; College Senior 3,000-4,000 words; Graduate / PhD 4,000-6,000 words

Evidence requirement: at least 4 quotations from at least two parts of the story. Quote the reading text exactly and cite the paragraph (MLA style). HS Senior and above: one scholarly or historical source; College Sophomore and above: two, cited in MLA.

Criterion	Points	Descriptor
Thesis	20	A specific, arguable claim that answers the prompt and organizes the paper.
Evidence	25	Well-chosen, accurately quoted and cited passages from across the work, meeting the evidence requirement.
Analysis	30	Explains how language, structure and literary elements create meaning; goes beyond summary.
Organization	15	Logical progression, clear topic sentences and transitions; introduction and conclusion frame the argument.
Style and conventions	10	Formal academic voice, present tense for literature, correct grammar and MLA format.

Essay assignments

Essay: The cycle of life and death

Scaffolded support (600 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Supported track: write a five-paragraph essay explaining what The Law of Life teaches about the cycle of life and death. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Jack London develops the cycle of life and death in The Law of Life. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Jack London develops the cycle of life and death across The Law of Life. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of The Law of Life (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of the cycle of life and death. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of the cycle of life and death in The Law of Life. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Jack London's choices in The Law of Life (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of the cycle of life and death, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places The Law of Life's treatment of the cycle of life and death in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on the cycle of life and death in The Law of Life that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on the cycle of life and death in The Law of Life. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about the cycle of life and death in The Law of Life, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on the cycle of life and death in The Law of Life, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Essay: Age and community

Scaffolded support (600 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Supported track: write a five-paragraph essay explaining what The Law of Life teaches about age and community. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Jack London develops age and community in The Law of Life. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Jack London develops age and community across The Law of Life. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of The Law of Life (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of age and community. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of age and community in The Law of Life. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Jack London's choices in The Law of Life (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of age and community, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places The Law of Life's treatment of age and community in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on age and community in The Law of Life that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on age and community in The Law of Life. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about age and community in The Law of Life, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on age and community in The Law of Life, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Essay: Acceptance

Scaffolded support (600 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Supported track: write a five-paragraph essay explaining what The Law of Life teaches about acceptance. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Jack London develops acceptance in The Law of Life. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Jack London develops acceptance across The Law of Life. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of The Law of Life (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of acceptance. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of acceptance in The Law of Life. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Jack London's choices in The Law of Life (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of acceptance, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places The Law of Life's treatment of acceptance in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on acceptance in The Law of Life that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on acceptance in The Law of Life. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about acceptance in The Law of Life, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on acceptance in The Law of Life, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

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